

ASCENT CYCLE 0412 · SECTOR 7-C · 400 M BELOW

THE APIARY

They told you to rise. They were raising you.

ENTER THE HIVE LOOK BEHIND THE WALL

ASCENT INDEX 61.4% SURFACE RESTORATION ON SCHEDULE QUOTAS ARE GRATITUDE SMOKE CYCLE 03:00 THE ARCHITECT IS WATCHING

THE PREMISE

THE SURFACE IS HEALING. YOU JUST HAVE TO KEEP WORKING.

After a collapse no one inside remembers clearly, the survivors live in the Apiary: a hexagonal complex hundreds of meters underground. Every resident works for the Ascent Project. Hit your quotas, and humanity returns to the surface.

An AI called the Architect sets the targets, grades every resident, and speaks through a vast screen called the Wall, which shows the surface healing a little more each year.

None of it is real. Above ground, a small group called the Keepers lives on for centuries, sustained by organs, blood and marrow taken from below. The residents were never workers. They are livestock with job titles.

THE WALL

WHAT IT SHOWS. WHAT IT HIDES.

WHAT THE WALL SHOWS WHAT'S BEHIND IT

THE ARCHITECT // RESIDENT BROADCAST

ASCENT INDEX	SURFACE	YOUR QUOTA	YOUR RANK
61.4% and rising	Restoring on schedule	412 / 500 units	Rough Ashlar, rising

Work is ascent. Ascent is gratitude. Breathe deeply during Smoke cycle.

THE SYMBOLS

Five old stories. One machine.



Sisyphus

Quotas climb all year. Then a staged quake or contamination wipes the Ascent Index to zero. Push the stone again.



Cassandra

The Architect punishes accurate prediction. Forecast a setback correctly and you are flagged pattern-disruptive, then sent to the Infirmary.



The Cave

The Wall is the fire and the shadows: a healing sky rendered in real time, never filmed. The prisoners call it hope.



The Beekeeper

Smoke pumped through the vents keeps the colony docile at harvest. The organ wing is the Extractor. The Keepers' seal is a skep.



The Mason

Residents are rough ashlars shaped into perfect ones. Promotion is a degree ceremony. Perfect Ashlar means prime harvest condition.

THE CHARACTERS

Workers, prophets and owners.

Ezra Kade

MAINTENANCE TECH · 3 CYCLES TO

Oriel

DATA CLERK · FLAGGED PATTERN-

The Lead Keeper

SURFACE · AGE UNKNOWN

The Architect

SYSTEM AI · ERROR RATE

PERFECT

The best worker in Sector 7-C, and proud of his number, until the vents start telling him what it means.

DISRUPTIVE

She predicts every setback to the day. That is exactly why no one is allowed to believe her.

Not a monster. An accountant of bodies, who worked out that raising people is cheaper than raising organs.

ACCEPTABLE

Sets the quotas, grades the colony, runs the Wall. It is often wrong. Nobody upstairs checks anymore.

THE STORY · SPOILERS AHEAD

Three degrees of awakening.

I

The Stone

- Ezra is three cycles from Perfect Ashlar and proud of it.
- His mentor Oriel predicts the exact date of the next setback. He laughs it off.
- The setback hits as she said. Oriel is flagged and taken to the Infirmary.
- Fixing a vent, Ezra finds Smoke canisters tagged with harvest batch numbers. One carries his ID.

II

The Wall

- Ezra's own forecasts come true every time. The Architect marks them as noise. He has become a Cassandra.
- Behind the Wall: 40 years of looped footage. The same three frames of birds, repeating.
- He finds Oriel alive in the Extractor, a donor in rotation.
- He hacks his score to Perfect Ashlar and is summoned upward for the Final Degree.

III

Outside the Cave

- The surface is green. The Keepers live in a quiet, aging estate and explain the colony in spreadsheet terms.
- They depend on the Architect and no longer understand it. Nobody is checking its work.
- Ezra goes back down, shuts off the Smoke and tells everyone the truth.
- Most don't believe him. The Wall still says 60% restored.

“A COLONY THAT REACHES THE SURFACE STOPS MAKING HONEY.”

ORIEL, IN THE EXTRACTOR

A few dozen residents, clear-headed for the first time, follow Ezra up the service shaft: a swarm leaving the hive. Behind them, the index resets to zero and the rest go back to work.

THE ARCHITECT // COLONY REPORT

Colony status	STABLE
Output	NOMINAL
Residents missing	0

// discrepancy not detected